‘Why don’t you keep that microphone out in the open? Why do you hide it under a telephone when I know the room is bugged?’

With a good measure of courage, I added:

‘I knew my phone was tapped when I was talking to my friends before I was implicated in the case.’

The men were now offended.

‘So you are a daredevil,’ mocked the man who has been asking for the Muslim name and went on to shower abuses on me. I noted him especially for his insults and cuss words and later figured out he was IB officer Jai Prakash.

Now I calmly replied that I had nothing to hide and hence I can dare them.

I kept asking for Special Investigation Branch DIG Siby Mathews, on whose instructions I was told I was taken for questioning. The interrogators asked me if I would tell the truth only if Siby Mathews met me. I said I just want to meet him since he is a senior officer who may understand me better. The DIG came on the third day for a meeting that lasted less than two minutes. The six-footer of an officer with thick lips and a moustache walked in and sat on the table top. I was seated on a chair.

‘Mr Nambi, why did you do this?’ he asked.

I looked him in the eye, but he evaded my gaze. ‘Do you think I would have done such a thing, Mr Siby?’

The officer murmured something and left me to the old set of interrogators who took turns to torture me till the next morning.

DOGS, GOATS AND OTHER SPACE SCIENTISTS

‘I am APJ Abdul Kalam, rocket engineer.’

When I chucked the sugar factory job and came home empty-handed, mother was happy. She was proud of me for getting an engineering